Transnational connections and barriers in DH: a UK-Chinese case study

Jing, Chen
cjchen@nju.edu.cn
Nanjing University, China

Spence, Paul Joseph
paul.spence@kcl.ac.uk
King's College London, United Kingdom

Global critique of digital humanities has long identified structural issues in the institutional and sociotechnical infrastructures underpinning digital humanities work as the drivers for historic and ongoing epistemic inequality in the field (Fiormonte et al. 2022, Chen/Tsui 2022). One of the key solutions to this challenge is to "[articulate] the long-standing nature and diverse trajectories of DH communities" beyond Anglophone DH and "the mono-myth of Busa" (Nilsson-Fernàndez and Dombrowski 2022), which includes recognising the local context shaping DH discourse and practice. Without recognising the different conditions of access and participation, we cannot construct true global collaboration in DH with geolinguistic inclusivity at its core (Galina Russell 2014, Gil / Ortega 2016, Spence 2021).

In 2024 we began a bi-national study in order to compare attitudes towards digital humanities identity formation, research infrastructures and professionalisation in UK and Chinese DH communities, in part using a UKCHA Collaborative Research Award from Exeter University. Our study included extensive literature review, the analysis of DH professional documentation in both countries, and a series of interviews (45 in total) with DH researchers, cultural heritage organisations, funders, policy organisations, publishers and software development companies working in the cultural space, including people leading on strategy in academic, creative and cultural industries, and digital innovation.

While such studies can never be fully comprehensive, we were able to capture a wide cross-section of views on the current state of the field, and here we wish to compare different responses in each country to four major areas: (1) dynamics of knowledge production; (2) professional structures; (3) global visibility; and (4) international collaboration.

Digital humanities researchers often like to talk about their research being at an intersection (Bol / Xia / Wang 2018). In another sense, and judging from our responses, some would argue that DH is at a crossroads in its history – no longer the new disruptor in academia, yet also not fully established as an academic structure with a loosely coherent research and teaching programme (Tsui 2020).

Overall, both sets of interviews revealed a similar set of general aspirations and preoccupations in the digital humanities. On the one hand, the field appears to be gaining greater formal institutional recognition in both countries and DH researchers often reported a degree of optimism about their prospects. On the other hand, serious challenges remain for career progression and evaluation, and DH's definitional fluidity sometimes poses challenges when attempting to situate DH in wider debates, for example around computational advances in the GLAM sector or the role of the humanities in addressing emerging debates about AI.

What is the current role of DH in creating new knowledge?

At the heart of any field should be the question: what kind of new knowledge is being created and what is its role in wider scientific enquiry? As might be expected, there was a wide variety of responses to these questions in our study, and in both countries, interviewees argued that DH allowed them to generate new methods of analysis, new kinds of data/research object, new kinds of research question, new forms of collaboration and new forms of rethinking the humanities.

In China, information science, librarianship, archives, history, and the arts are more receptive to digital humanities because these disciplines have more digital resources and are more willing to embrace digital methods, notably in areas such as computer vision and artificial intelligence. UK DH has a slightly broader disciplinary base, and there the digital humanities have increasingly become a recognised research area with its own centres and departments.

In both countries, there was a strong connection to the GLAM (Galleries, Libraries, Archives and Museums) sector and cultural heritage, and evidence of increasing opportunities to collaborate on computational approaches to working with large collections. In both countries, computational approaches are becoming increasingly well-

established, although there are concerns that DH should not allow itself to be defined solely by computational (or specifically quantitative) methods.

What professional structures exist to support DH research?

While Chinese DH constitutes an active and highly motivated community, it still does not enjoy the same level of official recognition which the UK DH community has started to attract in recent years. There are particular challenges in teaching/training programmes, funding and the top-down nature of educational governance in China. Chinese scholars have expressed dissatisfaction nationally with the current organizational structure of academia, and seek improvements in how DH research is evaluated, and the kinds of output which are recognised.

In the UK, there have been important advances – for example in developing semi-formal structures which recognise the role of Research Software Engineers in DH (King's Digital Lab 2019), or which map different stages of research lifecycles (King's Digital Lab 2020) – but there are also concerns that the fashionability of DH has in part led to weakening support for experimental research objects in favour of more traditional publication outputs.

In the UK, there are many established DH teaching programmes, but some argue that greater benchmarking would help to provide the field with a more solid foundation and foster career pathways to the GLAM and private sectors, whereas in China scholars often call for a more proactive approach in establishing teaching and training programmes.

What factors affect visibility and collaboration

Despite a fast-growing Chinese DH community (with over thirty DH centres) and a flurry of recent publications examining its status, Chinese DH enjoys far less visibility than that enjoyed by other national/regional communities such as the UK. This is due to both internal and external, historic, structural and linguistic reasons.

Respondents reported that their understanding of the West far surpassed the West's understanding of China. While language was cited as a barrier to visibility, interviewees tended to consider that a lack of equitable mechanisms and methods for fair and effective international exchange were more of an issue. Chinese respondents believe that digital humanities associations should play a greater advocacy role in promoting DH research, conducting targeted discussions on specific topics, and extending the scope of DH research beyond elite universities.

While researchers in the UK enjoy far higher visibility than their colleagues in other countries due to a combination of factors – including the early history of UK researchers in DH and structural bias towards Anglophone research in international publications – paradoxically the community has not until recently had a formal representation body. The recent creation of the UK-Ireland Digital Humanities Association has been an important factor in setting the foundations for stronger professional capacity-building, governance and outreach/partnerships (Gambell et al. 2021, Murphy et al. 2023).

Incentives and obstacles facing collaborations

UK and Chinese respondents reported markedly different factors which shaped their ability to create external collaborations. Whereas UK researchers most commonly reported Brexit as a limiting factor, for Chinese researchers the most common factors were problems of language, practical difficulties caused by political factors and mistrust in scholarly collaboration and exchange. Chinese interviewees suggested that they know far more about the UK or European digital humanities than the UK or other Western DH colleagues know about them. There are multiple translations from English into Chinese, but very little in the other direction.

In terms of experience with organizational forms, some scholars have suggested that projects like the CBDB (Chinese Biographical Database Project) have been successful not only because of their database research, but more importantly because of the project-centred network of scholars they have established with opportunities for mobility in both directions.

Conclusions

In our conclusions, we wish to explore how more comparative studies such as this one can form the basis for more stable and fairer international collaboration in DH.

We consider possible scenarios for fostering greater transnational exchange, using China and the UK as a case study:

- *Intercountry curriculum comparison* to identify similarities and differences in topics covered, or methodologies used. How can international virtual exchange be effectively facilitated across DH programmes in different countries, on macro or micro levels?
- *The international classroom*. Masters' programmes in the UK have a high proportion of international students, and yet this is largely an untapped resource in the classroom – we can take steps to more proactively recognise this and give these voices more agency in curriculum design
- Using both machine translation and in-cohort expertise (e.g. the high number of Chinese students in UK DH programmes at Masters' level), *literature review comparison* across programmes in both countries, exploring the different treatment of specific DH methods or topics
- One major issue which respondents identified was the lack of opportunities to interact with people from the other country. One solution might be to arrange *open ideation/hackathon events* around common historical or cultural events, e.g. in the case of UK/China, the Opium Wars, with invited participants from other humanities disciplines, GLAM sector and policy organisations.
- *Lobbying for shared funding*. Lobbying funders and professional organisations for support for seed funding for exploratory networking programmes around specific research topics, which might include non-academic partners.
- One interviewee argued for greater "calibration of topics and areas of interest" to bring this close to that which occurs at European level. *Open showcase of DH research* in virtual workshops between institutions in both countries to provide short research snapshots in each location, followed by brainstorming of possible research collaborations. This could potentially include invited speakers from cultural heritage, funding and policy organisations.

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